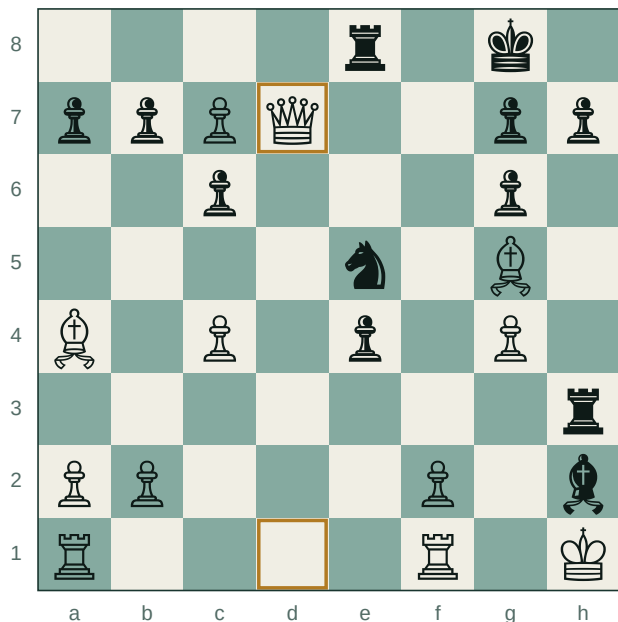


Hook mating nets: Black, move 21

Hook mating nets

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Qd7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Bf4+ 22. Kg1 Nf3+ 23. Kg2 Rh2#

21...Bf4+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The changed line means the rook on h3 attacks the king on h1. Recorded reply: **22.Kg1**.

22...Nf3+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f3 it attacks king on g1 and bishop on g5. Recorded reply: **23.Kg2**.

23...Rh2# Mate: rook on h2 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on g2. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on h2. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Recount the king's legal replies after each move. A changed pawn placement can destroy an otherwise familiar mating pattern.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A hook-type mating net combines rook pressure with knight control and supporting pawn geometry. The supporting pieces can matter more than the apparent value of a sacrifice.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the final checking line and then trace which friendly pieces protect the attacker and control the king's exits.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: queen on d7 and bishop on g5. Check for tactical protection.